

Lesson 1 A puma at large



Listen then answer the question below.

Where must the puma have come from?

Pumas are large, cat-like animals found in the Americas. When reports came into the London Zoo that a wild puma had been spotted 45 miles south of London, they were not taken seriously. However, as the evidence began to accumulate, experts from the zoo felt obligated to investigate, because the descriptions given by people who claimed to have seen the puma were extremely similar.

The hunt for the puma began in a small village where a woman picking blackberries saw 'a large cat' only five yards away. It immediately ran away when she saw it, and experts confirmed that a puma will not attack a person unless it is cornered. The search proved difficult, because the puma was often seen in one place in the morning and in another twenty miles away in the evening. Wherever it went, it left a trail behind of dead deer and small animals like rabbits. Paw prints were seen in several places and puma fur was found clinging to bushes. Several people reported hearing 'cat-like noises' at night and a businessman on a fishing trip saw the puma in a tree. The experts were now fully convinced that the animal was a puma, but where had it come from? Since no pumas had been reported missing from any zoo in the country, this one must have been owned by a private collector and somehow managed to escape. The hunt went on for several weeks, but the puma was not caught. It is disturbing to think that a dangerous wild animal is still at large in the quiet countryside.



New words and expressions

puma (title) /'pu:mə/ *n.* Large, wild American cat

spot /spɑ:t/ *v.* Notice or see

evidence /'evidəns/ *n.* Proof or signs of truth

accumulate /ə'kju:mjə,leɪt/ *v.* To gather and grow

obligate /'ɑ:blɪ,geɪt/ *v.* Must do, Forced to

hunt /hʌnt/ *n.* Search for animals

blackberry /'blæk,beri/ *n.* Dark, sweet berry.

person /'pɜ:rsən/ Human

corner /'kɔ:rnər/ *v.* Where two edges meet

trail /treɪl/ *n.* Sequence of footprints or signs

print /prɪnt/ *n.* Impression left by pressing.

cling /klɪŋ/ *v.* Hold on tightly

convince /kən'vɪns/ *v.* Make someone believe

somehow /'sʌm,haʊ/ *adv.* Don't know how

disturb /dɪ'stɜ:rb/ *v.* Causing anxiety or distress

Notes

1 **at large** This means something or someone is "on the loose" or roaming free, and they haven't been caught yet.

2 **...reports came into the London Zoo that a wild puma had been spotted...** It simply introduces the specific content of the report. It connects the "report" to what the report actually says.

3 **feel obligated to do...** This gives the feeling of a strong inner push. It means you feel it is your personal duty or responsibility to do something, even if nobody is strictly forcing you.